

win. Experience is said to be the best teacher, and Sabalenka has adopted a sensible perspective. After her third straight, three-set Grand Slam loss to an American — Anisimova 6-4, 4-6, 6-4 in the Wimbledon semifinal — Sabalenka said, “Losing sucks, you know? You always feel like you want to die, you don’t want to exist anymore, and this is the end of your life. But then you sit there a little bit, and you think about what you could have done differently in the match. I mean, you see stuff where you weren’t at your best in the match. You see that the other player performs much better. You kind of, like, can see things better.”

Easy to say, but not so easy to do, given the scar tissue this extremely emotional Belarusian has accumulated. Sabalenka relaxes on social media, where she has a huge following. In an *Instagram* video with Gauff, Sabalenka posted, “TikTok dances always had a way of bringing people together.”

It’s hard not to predict she will make the U.S. Open final — but once there, Sabalenka may falter yet again.

**Victoria Mboko** — This Cinderella from Canada said all the right things just as she hit the right shots during her breakthrough tournament at the National Bank Open in Montreal. After the wild card Victoria Vanessa Mboko staved off a match point to upset former Wimbledon champion Rybakina 1-6, 7-5, 7-6(4) in the semifinals, she was asked if she could win the title. She told the enchanted spectators, “Anything can happen.”

Indeed, it can — and it has. Energised by cheering fans waving ‘ALLEZ VICKY!’ signs and wearing oversized face masks of her, Mboko, at 18 years and 336 days, made history as the second-youngest woman in the Open Era to vanquish four Grand Slam champions at the same WTA event. (Serena, the women’s GOAT, was 17 when she won the 1999 U.S. Open.)

Besides Rybakina, Mboko knocked out 2020 Australian Open winner Sofia Kenin 6-2, 6-3, Gauff 6-1, 6-4, and Osaka, her childhood idol, 2-6,

6-4, 6-1. After she outclassed No. 2 Gauff for the biggest win of her budding career, *Tennis Channel* analyst Paul Annacone said, “What amazed me most is it looked like Mboko felt she didn’t have to play outside of her game, her comfort zone. Coco was off, but a lot of that was due to Mboko’s power and consistency.”

A strongly built 5’10”, Mboko can whack aces and pummel groundstrokes like Serena, but she can also change pace and tactics. Against Osaka, she conjured a disguised drop-shot winner to break serve for 3-1 in the deciding set. “Her willingness to run and trade groundstrokes and allow opponents to beat themselves, that’s the most impressive thing,” said *Tennis Channel’s* Mark Petchey.

Her Serena-like competitiveness repeatedly drew loud cheers from



**On the rise:** Victoria Mboko has skyrocketed from No. 333 to No. 24 this year. GETTY IMAGES

the crowd. She sustained a right wrist injury from a fall against Rybakina but received a favourable MRI result on the morning of the final.

When Osaka tapped a seemingly unreachable drop shot, Mboko fearlessly lunged and struck a forehand winner before landing on her stomach.

Mboko, the daughter of emigrants from the Democratic Republic of the Congo who first came to the U.S. and then moved to Canada, has skyrocketed from No. 333 to No. 24 this year. The U.S. Open will again showcase Mboko Magic when the latest teen queen captures her first Grand Slam title.